imperialist" struggle of the Cuban people. At the same time, not unnoticed by the Chinese and Cubans alike, he was more than reluctant to recognize the Cuban revolution as socialist, accept Castro as a Marxist, or commit himself ideologically to the defense of Cuba and put his country on a collision course with the United States. Even when the long-serving head of the Cuban Communist Party, Blas Roca, presented Khrushchev with the Cuban national banner as a symbol of the continuation of the Bolshevik Revolution, he responded by praising Cuba rather than socialism.[5]

Faced with the task of balancing Soviet relations between Washington and Beijing, Khrushchev had to figure out how to deal with Cuba in a way that would consolidate his claim to lead the world communist movement while avoiding a direct confrontation with the United States. Unexpectedly to Khrushchev and his aides, Castro's survival of the Bay of Pigs invasion and his public embrace of socialism presented a major challenge not only to Washington but also to Moscow. Khrushchev's cautious approach to the Cuban revolution was at odds with public pronouncements by Fidel Castro himself and his communist aides that associated their revolution as closely as possible not only with the Soviet Union but also with Marxism and socialism.

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FIDEL CASTRO'S "NEAR DEATH" EXPERIENCE AT THE BAY OF Pigs produced a dramatic shift in the regime's official rhetoric. In a speech given in Havana on May 1, International Workers' Day, adopted by communists throughout the world as their emblematic holiday, Castro declared that his revolution was socialist and asked lawyers to produce a new socialist constitution for Cuba. He also firmly positioned himself and his country on the socialist side of the world divide. "If Mr. Kennedy does not like socialism, well, we do not like imperialism!" declared Castro. "We do not like capitalism! We have as much right to protest over the existence of an imperialist-capitalist regime 90 miles from our coast as he feels he has to protest the existence of a socialist regime 90 miles from his coast." If anyone doubted his